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The discursive reconfiguration of political authority: ISIS, the Syrian civil war, and the transformation of power in *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah*

M.TRISTAN VEZIO

Blanquerna Ramon Llull University, School of Communication and International Relations

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Master Director: CARLES FERNANDEZ TORNÉ. PhD

Master Coordinator: SERGI CUTILLAS MARQUEZ

Thesis supervisor: MIGUEL FRANQUET DOS SANTOS SILVA. PhD

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ABSTRACT AND KEY WORDS

Abstract :

The rise and fall of the Islamic State's land-based Caliphate challenges the conventional understanding of political power. This paper examines the relationship between political power and discourse during the Syrian civil war through two propaganda magazines of the Islamic State (ISIS), *Dabiq* (2014-2016) and *Rumiyah* (2016-2017). Using Critical Discourse Analysis (Fairclough, 1992; Van Dijk, 2006) and Izquierdo Brichs Sociology of Power (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), the research argues that ISIS's territorial losses did not alter its underlying political and ideological project, but instead prompted a discursive adaptation that reshaped the relationship between material and symbolic resources sustaining its claim to authority. While *Dabiq* constructed the Caliphate, understood as an Islamic State, governed under Sharia law by a supreme leader that merges political and religious legitimacy (Caliph) through territorial control, military strengths, governance, and religious legitimacy, *Rumiyah* focused on global ideological mobilization, increasingly detaching political participation from territorial controls and highlighting the importance of ideological commitment and individual actions. This analysis therefore challenges a simplistic view of ISIS's evolution as a shift from a territorial to a global agenda, showing how the Caliphate sustained political authority through discursive adaptation despite the erosion of its territorial foundations. This study contributes to wider debates on how extremist organizations adapt to material setbacks.

Key Words : Islamic State, Propaganda, Critical Discourse Analysis, Political Legitimacy, Dabiq and Rumiyah magazines, Territorial decline, Discursive adaptation

INTRODUCTION

Rise of ISIS

The rise of the Islamic State (ISIS) in 2014, in Iraq, deeply changed the local conflicts and the global security in the the Middle East. Although Jihadism and Jihadist groups had been in the region well before 2014, ISIS sets itself apart by merging military takeovers, local governance, religious beliefs and a unique communication approach into a political aim. Instead of constructing themselves as a rebel or armed group, ISIS presented itself as a fully functional state apparatus helding power over land, people and institutions.

The roots of ISIS can be linked to the chaos caused by the 2003 U.S. invasion of Iraq, which broke down existing government institutions and created a long-lasting political and security gap (Brands and Feaver, 2017). The increase in sectarian violence, along with the sidelining of Sunni communities by the Iraqi government, created the conditions for jihadist groups to grow their power (Lund, 2012). The beginning of the Syrian civil war in 2011 made the situation even worse. The collapse of the Syrian state allowed ISIS to take over lands and proved itself as a concurent political system that could bring back stability, safety and religious rules. The proclamation of the Caliphate on 29 June 2014 was presented as the only valid political power for Muslims and marked a turning point of this change. Unlike earlier jihadist groups, which mainly focused on fighting against proclaimed enemies, ISIS stated that it had effectively reinstated an Islamic Political system with control over territories, judicial, administrative and religious structures. As numerous experts have pointed it out (Bunzel, 2015; Lister, 2014; Winter, 2015), this combined political and religious goal set ISIS apart from jihadist groups like *Al-Qaeda,* as they traded worldwide rebellion to prioritise territorial control**.** As a result, comprehending ISIS in Syria goes beyond explanation of terrorism studies. The group did not just fight against current Nation-States, it also sought to replace them. This success depended not only on military gains, but also, on perceptions that would validate their power, make the governance accepted and rally supporters beyond Syrian or Iraqi borders.

ISIS media apparatus

Communication played a crucial role in ISIS's political strategy. Instead of being just a supporting tool for military actions, propaganda became a key element to control, to justify

actions, and to attract fighters. ISIS made communication a part of its system, turning media production into a strategic tool for building their State and for gaining support whitin their territory (Ingram, 2016). Reasearchers have showed that no other terrorist groups had created such a communication infrastructure capable of doing so much in a structured way (Winter, 2015 ; Ingram 2016; Milton, 2021). ISIS built one advanced media infrastructure, merging magazines, high-definition films and documentaries, radio broadcasts, social media sites, and publications made in multiple languages aimed at local and international audiences. The Al-Hayat Media Center, Al-Furqan Foundation, Amaq News Agency, Al-Bayan Radio were part of this media network. Through multilingual publications, ISIS aimed to recruit foreign fighters, to encourage *hijrah* and to legitimise political authority (Bunker and Bunker, 2019). As Ingram (2016) pointed out, ISIS's strategic communication did not just pass on information but created what he called a "*competitive system of meaning*" supporting the vision of the Caliphate, rooted in the 7th Century leader Abu Bakr, the first Caliph. Likewise, Wignell and al. (2017) showed that ISIS propaganda systematically mixed languages and visual elements to normalize governance, validate authority and present violence as both politically essential and religiously required. Although ISIS propaganda disseminates political and ideological messages, this paper examines how these messages also function as discursive practices that construct political authority, legitimise violence, and shape relations of power (Wignell et al., 2017).

Dabiq

Among the publications produced by ISIS, *Dabiq* is a primary source to understand how ISIS was organized and expanded. The name *Dabiq* refers to a small village in northern Syria linked to an Islamic prophetic tradition about a final battle between Muslims and their foes (Wignell et al., 2017; Winter, 2015).

By choosing this name, ISIS connected the publication to a wider religious and historical story highlighting the sumbolic value of Syria in its ideology. In total, fifteen issues were released before the magazine closed in 2016. The release of *Dabiq* followed the announcement of the Caliphate on 29 June 2014. His launching happened at a time when ISIS had signicant territorial control over both Syria and Iraq and aimed at strengthening its newly formed political project. As a result, the magazine became almost the ISIS official communication channel. Unlike many past jihadist publications, *Dabiq* focused a lot on non-military activities including governance, religious matters, development of insitutions and daily life, giving readers a view of

the organisation and its achievements. For these reasons, our paper is focusing on Issue 1 (The Return of Khilafah) and Issue 7 (From Hypocrisy to Apostasy), which refer to important moments in the Syrian civil war (Ingram, 2016)

Rumiyah

In September 2016, ISIS replaced *Dabiq* with a new English-writen magazine named *Rumiyah*, meaning "Rome" in arabic. While keeping the same goal of sharing ISIS's beliefs with a worldwide audience, the magazine appeared in a very different political and military context. Unlike *Dabiq*, which was produced during the period of ISIS's territorial expansion, *Rumiyah* was launched as the organisation began to experience significant territorial losses in both Syria and Iraq. Military offensives led by the international coalition and local armed forces progressively weakened the Caliphate's territorial control, particularly around major cities such as Manbij, Fallujah, Mosul and later Raqqa. (Lister, 2014; Kaczkowski et al., 2021). The name *Rumiyah* has been carefully considered. Based on Islamic faith about end times, it represents the group's vision for the future growth of the Caliphate. It shows ISIS's long-term goal to extend its fight beyond the Middle East. (Van der Krogt, 2020). Similarly to *Dabiq, Rumiyah* included religious discussions, formal announcements, war updates, and ideological pieces within a digital magazine. It reached out more frequently to supporters beyond areas controlled by ISIS, showing how the group adjusted to new military situations. For this reason, *Rumiyah Issue 1,* is the second main source examined in this thesis. Along with Dabiq 1 and 7, it provides relevant data for an analysis as to how ISIS's official messages evolved from the time of gaining territory to the early stage of losing land. Our analysis does not claim to be exhaustive of all *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* issues.

Visual propaganda and strategic communication

The corpus of the three ssues combined articles with pictures, maps, visuals, and well-crafted designs to create professional publications. The high-quality level of ISIS's media production set it apart from others jihadist groups. With a consistent graphic style and color, published in various languages, English, Arabic or French, ISIS aimed to enhance the credibility of its message connecting with audiences across various cultural backgrounds (Winter, 2015; Ingram, 2016). As reminded by Kress and Van Leeuwen (2006), the meaning is created through

the interplay of both written and visual tools. While, our focus is mostly on the written aspects of the newspapers, the visual remain relevant as they support the narrative in both *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah*, to convey ISIS political and religious messages.

Research Gap and questions and our dissertation structure.

Although ISIS has been extensively studied, much of the work focused on terrorism, strategic communications, radicalization, or religious beliefs. Will see in the literature review how researchers analyzed how *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* were used to attract foreigners, to justify violence, and to spread ISIS's ideological views (Winter, 2015; Ingram, 2016; Wignell et al., 2017).

However, we found less research on ISIS's communication during the evolution of the War , especially with respect to the political power and legitimacy. By placing these magazines in their political political and military context, this study investigates how ISIS adjusted its communication to portray its authority, legitimacy, and mobilization throughout the Syrian civil war. To achieve this, this dissertation combines Norman Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) with Izquierdo Brichs' Sociology of Power. CDA is the study of how language shapes identities, legitimises political goals, and influences social realities. It goes beyond explaining what the text or document says. It analyzes *why* certain words are used to create a certain impact on readers (Fairclough, 1992). The sociology of power complements this approach by focusing on *how* political authority is created, sustained, and transformed. Together, these two frameworks allow us to analyze ISIS propaganda as more than just a communication method, but as a political practice tied to the group's larger goal of state-building. The dissertation is guided by the following research questions: How did the changing conditions of the Syrian civil war reshape the discursive construction of political authority, legitimacy, and participation in ISIS propaganda? This question is explored through three sub-questions: How does ISIS use language to create political legitimacy and authority? How is the Syrian civil war portrayed in ISIS propaganda magazines? How do *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* contribute to narratives of radicalization? To adress those research questions, we formulate the following hypothesis grounded in CDA and Sociology of power.

- **H1:** Changes in the Syrian Civil war and in ISIS's territorial position coincided with a shift in the discursive construction of political authority from legitimizing authority

through territorial governance and institutional capacity toward sustaining authority through ideological and symbolic resources beyond territorial control.

- **H2:** As ISIS territories change, its narratives of participation and mobilization shift from collective involvement in territorial state-building toward individual sacrifice, action, and continued jihad.
- **H3:** Although changes in the Syrian civil war influenced how ISIS exercised and mobilized power, they did not fundamentally change the religious and ideological foundations it used to legitimise its authority and violence.

1. LITERATURE REVIEW.

1.1 ISIS is more than a terrorist organization: a new political project

While early research often framed ISIS primarily through terrorism and jihadist insurgency, later studies highlighted its distinctive combination of military action and territorial governance. Lister (2014) shows how ISIS developed courts, taxation, schools, and public services alongside military operations. Bunzel (2015) argues that the June 2014 declaration of the Caliphate was not merely symbolic, but reflected ISIS's central ideological objective, linking political power to religious authority and presenting loyalty to the Caliphate as a religious duty. Similarly, Winter (2015) highlights how ISIS promoted administrative activities alongside military victories to demonstrate its capacity to govern and legitimise its political authority. However, while this literature provides important insights into ISIS's ideology and governance, less attention has been given to how these political aims were discursively articulated in its official publications and adapted to changing conditions. Propaganda magazines are often examined primarily as tools of recruitment or message dissemination, leaving underexplored how discourse itself constructed and justified political authority over time (Nacos, 2016). This dissertation addresses this gap by examining *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* as discursive spaces in which ISIS constructed authority, articulated legitimacy, and defined political participation.

1.2 ISIS Communication and Strategic Propaganda

Communication has been widely seen as a key part of ISIS's political strategy. Instead of being used for recruitment or fear tactics only, propaganda became a vital tool through which the group showcased its legitimacy, spread its beliefs and shared its vision of Islam and the Caliphate. Winter (2015) stated that ISIS created one of the most advanced media systems formed by a jihadist group. Through magazines, videos, social media, and official news sources the group shared a consistent story that mixed military achievements, religious authority, and governance. Likewise, Ingram (2016) mentions that ISIS's communication approach was aimed at building a *"competitve system of meaning"* showcasing the Caliphate as a valid alternative to the current international system. Other researchers have also pointed out the professionalism of ISIS's media efforts. Milton (2021) highlighted the group's capability to manage several communication platforms both in darkweb and digital platforms, while Nacos (2016) claimed that modern terrorist

groups increasingly depended on thoughtful communication to reach audiences boyond the battlefield.

1.3 *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* in the existing Literature

Both *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* have drawn considerable academic attention, due to their significacnce whithin ISIS's media aparatus. While both publications shared comparable ideological objectives, the prevailing consensus in research, is that they both reflect distinct periods in the group's political and military evolution. Studies focusing on *Dabiq* have predominantly examined its function in validating the Caliphate during the so called "expansion". Winter (2015) points that the magazine consistently depicted ISIS as a *functional state* by disseminating narratives concerning governance, religious authority and military successes. In a similar way, Wignell and al. (2017) illustrate *Dabiq's* use of rethoric to legitimise violence and extablish political dominion.

1.4 Islam, Ideology and Political Legitimacy

Religion obviously plays a fundamental role in the scholarly study of ISIS, not just as an spiritual concept, but as a central element to gain power and manage the territories. For ISIS, governance, leadership, and violence are religious duties based on its Salafi-jihadist view of Islam. Bunzel (2015) states that ISIS's announcement of the Caliphate marked the peak of a long-term ideological aim based in Salafi-Jihadist ideas rooted. Similarly Berger (2015) and Welch (2018) indicate that religious stories are regularly used to support a political project, legitimise violence, and strenghen the duty to follow the ISIS leader. From this viewpoint, ideas like *Khilafah, Hijrah, Jihad,* and *Sharia* serve not just as religious references but also as political tools that ISIS use to build its legitimacy. Intead, religion is a source of political legitimacy, offering the ideological base from which the group validates its power and its wider ambitions for state-building. This viewpoint is specially important for this paper, which looks into how this religious stories are presented in *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* to back-up ISIS's assertions of political authority.

1.5 Critical Discourse Analysis

Instead of viewing discourse as an unbiased reflection of a context, CDA sees language as a social activity that both influences and is influenced by political and social situations (Fairclough, 1992; 2003).

Many researchers have used CDA to analyze ISIS propaganda. Wignell et al. (2017) show how *Dabiq* uses language techniques to justify violence, build political power, and make a clear separation between followers and enemies.

Likewise, Van der Krogt study on discourses reveal that ISIS consistently incorporated religious references, word choices, and storytelling format to normalize the political agenda. Based on his work, this dissertation uses Fairclough's three dimensional framework to explore how discourses play a role in building political power and legitimacy in *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah*. (Van der Krogt, 2020)

1.6 Sociology of Power

While ISIS had been studies from the viewpoints of terrorism studies, or strategic messaging, this study will use political power theories. (Nacos, 2016; Winter, 2017). The sociology of power, creating and developped by Ferran Izquierdo Brichs (2012) provides an additional value by understanding power as a social connection based on the use of sharing resources. Instead of reducing legitimacy to military power, Sociology of power highlights the significance of symbolic and ideological tools in supporting authority. This viewpoint is significant for examining ISIS. Although the group relied on force and military agression, it also put significant efforts into creating stories to make its political objectives valid. Religious ideas, portrayals of governance, and claims to sovereignty all helped to represent the Caliphate as a legitimate political body rather than just an armed group. By using the sociology of power alongside CDA, this dissertation investigates ISIS propaganda not just as a means of communication but also as a political action through which authority, legitimacy, and power are built and preserved.

1.7 Modality

Beyond written communication, research highlights the importance of visual messaging in ISIS propaganda. *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* combine text, images, maps, typography, and graphics to construct ideological narratives. Drawing on Kress and van Leeuwen's (2006) multimodal framework, Tan et al. (2018) argue that extremist propaganda should be understood as a multimodal phenomenon in which visual and written elements work together to construct meaning, shape identity, and frame violence. Similarly, Wignell et al. (2017) show how ISIS deliberately combines linguistic and visual elements to reinforce political power and ideological narratives. While this dissertation primarily adopts a CDA approach, visual elements are considered when they support the construction of political authority and legitimacy in the corpus. Overall, the literature shows that ISIS operates as both a political and discursive actor, using propaganda to construct legitimacy, ideological narratives, and political authority. Research on *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah*, combined with CDA, sociology of power, and multimodal approaches, provides the basis for examining how ISIS constructs political power through discourse. The next chapter presents the methodology used to analyse *Dabiq* 1 and 7 and *Rumiyah* 1.

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Approach

This study adopts a qualitative research approach to examine how *Dabiq 1* and 7, and *Rumiyah 1,* constructs narrative of radicalization, legitimacy and political authority through discourse. A qualitative methodology is appropriate because the research focuses on meanings, ideological narratives, representations, and symbolic forms of power rather than statistical measurement. It examines how language, religious references, political narratives, and visual symbolism represent the Syrian war and contribute to legitimizing violence and the Caliphate's political and religious authority. Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) is particularly relevant for examining the relationship between language, ideology, and power. Drawing on Fairclough and van Dijk, the study analyses how discourse constructs political legitimacy, social identities, and ideological divisions between "us" and "them." The analysis is complemented by the sociology of power to examine how ISIS transforms religious and political discourse into forms of symbolic authority and domination. It is described by Izquierdo Brichs, in *Sociology of Power in the Arab*

world (2009), as a "*useful tool for systematizing the analysis of power structures governing any society"* (2009, p. 19). This combined approach allows the study to understand ISIS propaganda not simply as extremist communication, but as a political and ideological mechanism through which the Syrian civil war is represented as a religious, political, and civilizational struggle.

2.2 Data Collection

The main sources reviewed in this research are the primary ISIS propaganda magazines *Dabiq* 1 and 7 and *Rumiyah 1*, which were published from 2014 to 2017 during the growth and fall of the Islamic State group . We also worked on secondary academic sources like articles, books, and researches related to jihadist propaganda, radicalization, terrorism, CDA and the sociology of power. Special focus was given to the works of Charlie Winter, Haroro J. Ingram, Norman Fairclough, Teun van Dijk, Ruth Wodak, and Ferran Izquierdo Brichs, whose studies offer recognized theoretical and methodological support for this research.

2.3 Critical Discourse Analysis

Following Fairclough's CDA framework, the analysis was conducted in several stages. First, a close reading of the selected issues of *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah* was undertaken in order to identify recurring themes, narratives, and representations related to the Syrian civil war. Second, passages referring to political authority, religious legitimacy, jihad, martyrdom, governance, enemies, and the caliphate were selected and coded according to their thematic relevance. Third, the analysis focused on specific linguistic and discursive features, including lexical choices, metaphors, religious references, intertextuality, and binary oppositions such as "believers versus unbelievers" and "Islam versus the West". Fourth, the study examined how these discursive elements contributed to the construction of legitimacy and symbolic power. Particular attention was given to the ways in which ISIS represented itself as a sovereign political entity and framed the war as both a religious obligation and a civilizational war. Finally, the identified discourses were interpreted in relation to the broader political and historical context of the war, allowing the analysis to connect textual features with wider processes of ideological production and power relations

CDA is especially relevant since it looks at the connection between language, power, and ideology, enabling the researcher to study how language is used to shape views, defend violence,

and build social identities. Through this lens, ISIS propaganda can be seen not just as communication, but as a carefully planned political tool aimed at shaping beliefs, rallying supporters, and validating authority.

2.4 Analytical procedure

The study analyses three publications—two issues of *Dabiq* and one of *Rumiyah*—selected for their detailed treatment of the Syrian civil war, ISIS's political agenda, and religious legitimacy. The issues were read as complete publications rather than as individual articles to identify recurring themes and patterns in ISIS's communication strategy, with particular attention to concepts such as *jihad*, martyrdom, governance, the caliphate, religious duty, and the enemies of Islam. The analysis applies Fairclough's three-dimensional CDA framework, examining textual choices, discursive practices, and broader structures of power. It focuses on religious references, intertextuality, binary oppositions such as "believers" and "non-believers", and strategies of legitimation. Finally, these discursive practices are connected to broader power dynamics, examining how ISIS transformed military achievements, religious symbols, and political claims into forms of political and symbolic authority. The magazines are therefore approached as instruments for constructing legitimacy, authority, and mobilisation through discourse.

2.5 Limitations

This research has several limitations. First, the study looked only at the propaganda magazines *Dabiq* and *Rumiyah*, which means that other types of ISIS communication such as videos, speeches, and social media were not examined closely. Secondly, the research depended on secondary qualitative information and did not include interviews or direct field studies. Another limitation involved the personal dimension of discourse analysis. Because CDA requires interpretation, different academics might have different opinions on same texts. Lastly, access to some original ISIS materials and archives may be restricted because of legal and safety concerns, especially with respect extremist online content. Regardless with these restrictions, the chosen method is suitable for understanding how ISIS propaganda builds stories of legitimacy, sovereignty, and radicalization through language and symbolic representation.

2.6 Ethics

This study analyzed propaganda material created by ISIS, which triggers legitimate ethical questions. The aim of this paper is purely academic and is not intended to support, validate or endorse any extremist beliefs in any way. The material reviewed in this paper was used exclusively for research purposes to understand how ISIS built its legitimacy, authority, and ideological messages. The research only used publicly available academic resources and secondary research. There were no direct, nor indirect contacts with any extemist groups or individuals. The visuals contained in the magazines are intentionally not shown in this thesis.

3. ANALYSIS *DABIQ*

3.1 Contextualizing *Dabiq*

The discourse in *Dabiq* cannot be examined independently from the political and military context in which it emerged. Following Fairclough (1992,2003), discourse both reflects and contributes to broader social practices. Accordingly, magazines must be analyzed in relation to ISIS's territorial expansion and state-building project between 2014 and 2016. Under Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi's leadership, ISIS no longer portrayed itself solely as a jihadist movement but claimed to have re-established a legitimate political and religious authority exercising sovereignty over territory and population (Bunzel, 2015; Lister, 2014; Winter, 2015). ISIS's rapid territorial expansion between 2014 and 2015 provided the material conditions upon which these claims could be sustained. By emphasising governance, judicial institutions, taxation, and public administration, *Dabiq* presented the Caliphate as an existing political reality rather than a future aspiration.

Unlike earlier jihadist publications, *Dabiq* devoted significant attention to governance and institution-building, portraying ISIS as a functioning state rather than merely an armed movement. As Winter (2015) argues, the magazine projected statehood alongside military success, while Ingram (2016) identifies *Dabiq* as a core instrument of ISIS's broader strategic communication campaign. Our study of *Dabiq* is structured around two supportive analytical areas. The first looks at *how* the magazine verbally shapes political power, by showing ISIS as a valid ruling State through discursive practices, using specific terms and visuals. The second investigates *how* religious and end-of-time prophetic stories add to the creation of legitimacy by presenting political power, violence and leadership as approved by morality and destined to happen. The choice of certain terms and visuals are intentionally present to support the political objectives and to help the recruitment of followers including beyond the region.

3.2 Constructing political authority

The legitimacy of ISIS has been progressively built starting with a name and some associated symbols and then with some concrete political actions.

3.2.1 Naming and defining the Islamic State

The establishment of political power starts with the way the political actors describe themselves. From a CDA lens, naming is not a simple choice of words but a way of communicating that builds legitimacy and power (Fairclough, 1992 ; Riesigl&Wodak, 2009). Throughout *Dabiq 1,* ISIS consistently uses certain word choices depicting ISIS as a pre-existing sovereign state instead of a rebel group. The regular terms like *Islamic State (Dabiq 1 p.2-5-8-9), Khilafah* (*Dabiq 1 p.6-7*)*,* and *Immam* (*Dabiq 1 p.17-18*) helps shaping an environment where ISIS appears like the legitimate representative of not only ISIS followers, but the entire Muslim Community in a wide project of state-building.Instead of showing itself as a insurgent group striving for political power, ISIS always calls itself an established state with control over land and people. From the viewpoint of sociology of power (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012) this way of speaking shows an effort to change symbolic resources into political power. By consistently calling itself the Islamic State, ISIS uses religious references (*hadith* for example) or symbols (black flag) to reinforce its predominancy over other political groups in Syria and Iraq. By showing statehood as an obvious truth, *Dabiq* motivates readers to see the Caliphate not as a goal, but as a real political system that deserves acknowledgment and loyalty.

3.2.2 Constructing the Caliphate as the unique legitimate authority

Beyond naming itself the *Islamic State*, *Dabiq* constructs the Caliphate as the only legitimate political authority for Muslims. As Benraad (2016) argues, the proclamation of the Caliphate was a strategy of political legitimation through which ISIS claimed exclusive Islamic sovereignty. This claim is explicit in *The Return of Khilafah*, where the magazine proclaims that *"the Khilafah has returned"* (*Dabiq* 1, pp. 6–7) and that *"the legality of all emirates, groups, states and organizations becomes null by the expansion of the Khilafah's authority"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 7). Through these formulations, ISIS discursively delegitimises all competing political authorities while presenting the Caliphate as the sole legitimate form of Islamic governance. This discourse is reinforced in *Dabiq* 7, which states that *"The Islamic State is a true Imamah"* (*Dabiq* 7, p. 20) and has become *"an unquestionable imamah"* through *"victory, consolidation and establishing*

the religion" (*Dabiq* 7, p. 21). From the perspective of the Sociology of Power (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), the Caliphate becomes a symbolic resource through which ISIS monopolises political legitimacy and demonstrates territorial gains.

3.2.3 Who's in and who's out: creating in and out groups

The building of political power in *Dabiq* depends on military and territorial gains but also on who is part of the political group. The discourse creates shared identities by identifying proper members from those who should be left out (Van Dijk, 1998; Reisigl&Wodak,2009).

In *Dabiq* 1, ISIS systematically distinguishes between "*the camp of Islam and faith*" and "*the group of Kufr and hypocrisy*" (*Dabiq* 1, p. 28). This two-part contrast from the basis upon which the group builds its political credibility. Rather than portraying the war, as a traditional political and military battlefield, *Dabiq 1* reframes it as a life-and-death battle between two completely irreconciable communities. This idea is strengthened by the claim that *"the world today has been divided into two groups and two trenches"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 10), leaving no space for neutrality or diverse political views. Simultaneously, the in-group is often labeled using terms like *"the believers", "the muwahhidin"* and "*the true Muslims"*(*Dabiq* 1, p.43-44;47-49). From a CDA viewpoint, these word choices demostrates what Van Dijk (2006) calls positive self-representation and negative other representation where identity is formed through the simultaneous praise of the in-group and the disqualification of the out-group. This approach is endorsed by the organized labeling of opponents as "*crusaders*", "*apostates*" (p.44), or rafidah and murtaddin, terms that imply moral and religious disapproval instead of neutral political terms. From sociology of power perspective (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), these limits determine who has the right to be part of the organisation (and should), while justifying violent actions against the outsiders ("*Kufr"Dabiq 1 p.28-33-35).* The formation of in-groups and out-groups thus, helps building a state. Instead of explaining ideological splits, *Dabiq* actively creates political belonging whose unity relies on the exclusion of opposing identites and powers. The communication becomes a tool through which ISIS strengthens its claim to unique political and religious authority.

3.2.4 Naturalizing Governance: Violence and state-building

While the previous sections showed how *Dabiq* constructs political authority through processes of nomination and collective identity, it also presents ISIS rule as a normalised form of governance. This is particularly visible in *Dabiq* 1 and 7, where government institutions, land management, taxation (*zakat*), public services, markets, and legal activities are presented as routine functions of a working state. Rather than focusing solely on military propaganda, the magazines document administrative structures and their effectiveness, encouraging readers to perceive the Caliphate as an established political body rather than a radical insurgent group. The repeated use of institutional terms such as *Diwan* and *Wilayat*, alongside administrative and war reports, transforms territorial control and military success into evidence of political stability and authority (*Dabiq* 7). This relationship between territorial control and political legitimacy is explicit in *Imamah is from the Millah of Ibrahim*. *Dabiq* states that *"The Islamic State is a true Imamah"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 20) and, through *"victory, consolidation and establishing the religion,"* has become *"an unquestionable imamah"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 21). Military success is therefore discursively transformed into evidence of legitimate sovereignty, presenting territorial control as proof of political authority rather than merely the outcome of armed conflict. A similar logic applies to coercion. In *Dabiq* 7, *hudud* punishments are incorporated into routine administrative reporting. The magazine states that the Islamic State continues its mission by *"implementing the rulings of Allah"* and cites the Prophetic tradition that *"the implementation of one hadd in the land is better for the people of the Earth than for it to rain for forty mornings"* (*Dabiq* 7, p. 43). By embedding punishment within a legal and religious framework, coercion is represented as a legitimate function of governance. The accompanying visuals (*Dabiq* 7, pp. 42–43) further reinforce this representation by making the exercise of state authority visible.

3.3 Producing legitimate power through religious and apocalyptic narratives

Political power cannot last eternally by using force only; it must also be perceived as rightful to a certain extent. As Berger (2015) states, ISIS always presents religion as the main source of political rightness.

3.3.1 Religious Legitimation of Political Authority

In *Dabiq,* religious languages from, *Qur'an,* the *Sunna,* and Islamic tradition, not only makes the Caliphate's power acceptable, but also present it as a sacred duty, connecting the war to a larger prophetic destiny for the muslims. Political statements are regularly backed by verses from the Qur'an, sayings of the Prophet, and mentions of the earliest followers of Islam, shifting political power from man-made systems to God's authority. Instead of showing the Caliphate as a new reality, *Dabiq,* describes it as the ongoing practice of a true Islamic political system set up by divine guidance. This strategy is particularly clear in the section "*Imamah is from the Millah of Ibrahim*" (pp.21-24). Political leadership is grounded in religious doctrine. The article state that : "*The Islamic State is a true Imamah*" (*Dabiq*, p.20) and argues that, "*victory, consolidation and establishing the religion*", has become *"an unquestionable immah"* (*Dabiq*, p.21). Political legitimacy is thus shown as the result of religious accomplishment rather than just military victory. The ongoing link between leadership and divine direction strengthens the belief that the Caliphate gets its power directly from Islamic customs. Religious mentions are used to strengthen loyalty to the new political system. Across *Dabiq*, quotes from the Qur'an and sayings of the Prophet enhance talks about governance, *jihad*, and leadership, presenting loyalty to the Caliphate as directly linked to loyalty to God. The use of Holy texts, intertwined by political power, the magazine elevates it beyond everyday political conversation and raises it to a level of religious duty. Religion thus serves as the main tool through which *Dabiq* changes political power into accepted authority. Instead of simply supporting the political aims of the Islamic State, religious dialogue offers the text-based grounds on which the Caliphate's power is built and defended.

3.3.2 Constructing Divine Obligation

Dabiq transforms religious beliefs into political obligations supporting the Caliphate. Loyalty, migration, and belonging are presented not as personal choices but as religious duties. *Bay'ah*, or the oath of loyalty, is presented as a key requirement for legitimate political membership. By turning obedience into a matter of faith, *Dabiq* strengthens political authority around the Caliph. From the sociology of power perspective (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), religious authority is thus converted into political loyalty, reinforcing ISIS's power over Muslims. This legitimation is also reinforced visually. In *Dabiq* 1, the discussion of obedience to the imam is accompanied by a prominent image of the Kaʿbah. Drawing on Kress and van Leeuwen's (2006)

concepts of salience and composition, the visual prominence of this sacred space connects political obedience to a religiously charged setting. *Hijrah* is presented as a consequence of accepting the Caliphate's legitimacy. The magazine states that *"Hijrah will not stop as long as there is jihad"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 36), transforming migration to Syria from an optional choice into an ongoing religious duty. As Ingram (2016) argues, ISIS consistently presents migration as a core form of participation in the Caliphate, making *hijrah,* both an expression of devotion and a means of expanding the political community. Finally, *jihad* is framed as the practical expression of loyalty and migration. Rather than presenting armed struggle as a military choice, *Dabiq* constructs it as a religious obligation. In *Dabiq* 7, violence is repeatedly justified through religious language and framed as a duty to protect and uphold the Islamic State. As Bunzel (2015) notes, ISIS systematically connects *jihad* to broader political aims, allowing violence to be presented as a rightful and essential expression of faith. Together, *bay'ah*, *hijrah*, and *jihad* construct citizenship through divinely mandated political commitment to the Caliphate.

3.3.3 Apocalyptic Narrative/ Framing and Prophetic Destiny

Dabiq situates the Syrian civil war within a broader eschatological narrative. Rather than representing the conflict as a conventional civil war, the magazine reframes it as the fulfilment of Islamic prophecy, transforming contemporary political events into evidence of a divinely ordained historical process. This apocalyptic framing is introduced from the very first pages of *Dabiq*. The opening issue recalls Abu Mus'ab al-Zarqawi's declaration that : "*The spark has been lit here in Iraq, and it's heat will continue to intensify – by Allah's permission – until il burns the crusaders armies in Dabiq*" (*Dabiq* 1 p.3). It furthers explains, that according to the hadith, *"the area will play a historical role in the battles leading up to the conquest of Constantinople, then Rome"* (*Dabiq* 1 p.6). By grounding its political project in prophetic geography, ISIS transforms northern Syria from a battlefield into the divinely designated location of the final confrontation between Islam and its enemies in *Dabiq* (Rasoulikolamaki & Kaur, 2021). The same reasoning applies to the selection of the magazine's name.

Dabiq repeats prophetic sayings indicating that, once the forces assemble in Sham *"the prayer is called. So 'Isa Ibn Maryam ('alayhis-salam) will descend and lead them"* (*Dabiq* 1, p. 5). Military conflict is thus shown not just as a fight for land ownership but as the continuation of holy

history. Current political situations are viewed in light of future predictions, justifying the creation of the Caliphate as part of God's plans, instead of being an historical coincidence. Although *Dabiq 7* focuses more on governance, it continues to embed political authority within an apocalyptic worldview. By presenting the Syrian civil war as the fulfilment of divine prophecy, *Dabiq* reinforces the Caliphate's legitimacy through symbolic and religious authority (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), illustrating how discourse reshapes the representation of the conflict.

4. ANALYSIS RUMIYAH

4.1 Context

By the middle of 2016, the group had lost territories in Syria and Iraq, while important cities like Mosul and Raqqa were besieged (Lister, 2014; Winter,2017). These changes impacted upon ISIS's communication. The first edition of *Rumiyah* was released in September 2016, replacing *Dabiq*. ISIS changed its core message to accommodate the new situation. As Ingram (2016) pointed out, the group's messages stayed very much in tune with its strategic situation, changing its stories to maintain credibility even as military conditions changed. As a result, *Rumiyah* focuses much less on ruling, organizations, and land ownership compared to *Dabiq*. Instead, it encourages worldwide *Jihad* and the ongoing fight beyond the Caliphate's borders.

Following Fairclough (1992; 2003), discourse must be studied in connection to its conditions of creation. The next sections will show how *Rumiyah* alters legitimacy, authority, and gathering support in reaction to the group's shifting political and military situation.

4.2 Constructing Political Authority without Territory

4.2.1 Ideological Continuity beyond Territorial Loss: What remains unchanged?

Military defeat does not necessarily entail the immediate collapse of political authority. The magazine explicitly declares that "*the Khilafah Remains*" and that "*the ideology of the Islamic State will remain*" (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 2). This lexical continuity is significant because it prevents territorial loss from being equated with political disappearance. By maintaining the same political and religious terminology, *Rumiyah* presents the Caliphate as an ongoing political project despite its changing material conditions. This is reinforced by the claim that "*the fighters of the Khilafah are numerous" (Rumiyah* 1, p. 2), which shifts attention from the territory controlled by ISIS towards the continued existence of its supporters. The transformation of the Syrian civil war did not immediately produce a rupture in the organisation's political identity; instead, *Rumiyah* preserves this identity while adapting it to the realities of territorial decline.

4.2.2 Legitimacy through Persistence and Resilience: Changing the meaning of Defeat.

Defeat is seen as a temporary situation, that reinforces the moral authority of the organisation in the long term. Contextually, this follows the passing of ISIS spokesperson Abu Muhammad al-Adnani and the first editorial of *Rumiyah 1,* just weeks after his passing. His picture is the front page of the number. Rejecting the belief that the loss of leaders harms the organization, *Rumiyah* claims that "*Allah preserves His religion however He wills, and this religion will remain established and will not be damaged by the death of any person*" (Rumiyah 1 p2.) The same point is supported by showing persistence as a key feature of the movement. The magazine mentions that *"the death of their leaders and commanders... only increases their firmness and determination in fighting the enemies of Allah" (Rumiyah 1 p.3)* before ending by *"whenever a generation of them passes, another generation follows, holding the banner of tawhid overhead" (Rumiyah 1 p.3).* Military setbacks are framed as an evidence of ideological resistance rather than ISIS decline as an organisation. Caliphate authenticity is proven by sacrifice and endurance in the path towards *Caliphate.*

Always from a CDA perspective, *Rumiyah,* challenges the meaning of defeat by substituting stories of winning with stories of determination. From the view of sociology of power (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), strenghts become a meaningful tool through which ISIS maintains political credibility despite the loss of massive terriroty. As a result, *Rumiyah* showed how the changes in the Syrian civil war altered the bases of ISIS's power, moving legitimacy from military achievement to belief resilience.

4.2.3 From a Caliphate state to a Caliphate idea

The most significant change in *Rumiyah* is not the giving up of the Caliphate but the new understanding of its political meaning. While *Dabiq* marketed the Caliphate thanks to its control over land, its leadership, and government bodies, *Rumiyah* progressively separates political power from controlling land. The Caliphate is now no longer mentioned as a state-to-be-run, but as an idea-based community that can live on and on even if it has lost lands. This change was gradually turning the Caliphate into an idea as *Rumiyah* emphasizes that *"the ideology of [the] Islamic State will remain"* (*Rumiyah* p.2). The lasting existence of the Caliphate, is shown by immateriality, the continuation of an idea.

Then, the power is moved from the organization to the group of believers. While *Dabiq* often justified the Caliphate through rule, legal power, and management systems, *Rumiyah* states that *"whenever one generation of them passes, another generation follows, holding the banner of tawhid overhead"(Rumiyah 1, p.3).*Power lasts as long as the belief lasts.

Finally, *Rumiyah* takes political legitimacy away from the area of historical uncertainty by basing it on divine permamence. The claim that *"Allah preserves His religion however He wills" (Rumiyah 1 p.2)* removes territorial loss of its political importance. If the ongoing existence of the Caliphate relies on divine will instead of military power, then defeat can never undermine its legitimacy. Military weakening is verbally countered since political authority is shifted away from the battlefield.

The discursive transformation observed in *Rumiyah* illustrates Fairclough's concept of recontextualization, whereby political authority is reconstructed in response to changing social conditions. As territorial sovereignty declines, ideological and religious resources replace territorial governance as the primary basis of legitimacy. In terms of the sociology of power (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012), this reflects a process of deterritorialization through which the Caliphate is discursively redefined from a territorial reality into a transnational ideological project.

4.2.4 Reframing Authority beyond Territorial Governance.

What kind of political authority is left once ISIS has lost its control over territories? *Rumiyah* answers this question by removing all the administrative discourses that were defining *Dabiq*. References to governance, community organizations, and land management are substituted by frequent appeals to personal actions and faithfulness to religion. Readers are urged to meet their responsabilities toward the Islamic State no matter where they are in the world, while involvment in politics and *hijra* becomes less connected than the connection to beliefs. This reflects the shift in ISIS's mobilisation strategy identified by Ingram (2016), whereby participation can increasingly be constructed through individualised forms of engagement rather than direct incorporation into a territorial organisation. Power is thus exerted less by controlling a land, population, within State control, but more by managing the actions and thoughts of scattered followers outside the Caliphate. This reconfiguration in power is also shown in the magazine's way of communicating. Unlike *Dabiq*, *Rumiyah* more often uses a commanding language that tells, orders and encourage its readers. Power is shown less through the display of violence or

working systems and more through constant reminders of loyalty, faith, and personal duty. For instance, it says ***"****kill the disbelievers in any manner possible" (Rumiyah 1 p.10).* In doing so, the magazine reconstructs political authority as a relationship between the organisation and its followers rather than between a state and its citizens, illustrating what Izquierdo Brichs (2012) describes as the progressive displacement of political authority from institutional structures towards symbolic and ideological forms of power. It is relevant to note that the visuals in *Rumiyah* are also significantly fewer and less focusing on military actions and are more religious or sociatel oriented (*Rumiyah 1 p.4 to p.8, p.11 to p.14 and 18 to p.21).*

4.3 Transforming power: From territorial rule to global mobilization in Rumiyah

4.3.1 From Territorial Sovereignty to Transnational Mobilization

Rumiyah continues to present *hijrah* as a pillar of the community of believers (*jama'ah*), alongside obedience and *jihad* (*Rumiyah* 1, pp. 7–8). However, this emphasis coexists with a new form of belonging in which participation in ISIS no longer depends on physical presence in territories under its control. This transformation is particularly visible in *"Among the Believers Are Men,"* which presents the biography of Abu Mansur Al Muhajir (*Rumiyah* 1, pp. 16–17). Rather than portraying him simply as a lone fighter, the magazine constructs his biography as an exemplary narrative. Originally from Australia, Abu Mansur travels to Sham, performs *hijrah*, and participates in fighting in Syria (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 16). The narrative then shifts from his experience in Syria to a direct message to Muslims in Australia, presenting their dispersion across the *"various lands of the Crusaders"* as a condition from which they can still participate (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 17). This shift from biography to direct address redefines participation: physical distance from the battlefield no longer excludes individuals from *jihad*, but becomes compatible with involvement in the same political struggle. *Rumiyah* nevertheless continues to showcase territorial fighting, including operations in Al-Hasak province, Shaddadi, and Kashkash Jubur against the PKK in Syria (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 22), alongside actions in Iraq and elsewhere. As Ingram (2016) argues, ISIS messaging is strategically adaptive. The changing conditions of the Syrian conflict therefore reshaped not only its propaganda, but also the geographical boundaries through which political participation and radicalisation could be constructed.

4.3.2 Transforming the meaning of mujahedeen and jund

If political participation is no longer defined exclusively by territorial presence, what does it mean to be a *mujahid* in *Rumiyah* discourse propaganda? We can find the answer in the section "*Among the Believers are Men" (pp.14-18)* and in the next section *"O Women, Give Charity" (pp.18-22).* In the latter, Abu Mansur is presented as the ideal *Mujahid*, an example to follow. From CDA perspective, the way Abu Mansur story is selected to remember the audience, what a committed member of ISIS should be, even with the geopolitical conditions changing in Syria in Iraq. The text depicts Abu Mansur as a *muhajir (*migrant) and a *mujahid (*fighter) and an example *"in general" (Rumiyah 1,* p.16). This change from one person to a broader character is significant. Abu Mansur is shown not just as a fighter for ISIS, but as a role model. His *"strong 'aqidah" [credo, dogma]* is described as having inspired his companions, who remained with him despite heavy bombardment (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 17). By moving from his individual experience in Syria to the direct address of *"the lions of the Ummah*" and Muslims in Australia, *Rumiyah* changed the function of the biography itself: Abu Mansur is no longer the object of the narrative but becomes a discursive model through which action is prescribed to others (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 17). This also alters how authority is repeated.

This is especially meaningful in times of losing territory: when ISIS cannot physically bring people in, it can still include them through language, using propaganda. The territorial fighter remains the ideal reference point, but its qualities are detached from his geographical location and presented as reproducible everywhere. *Rumiyah* thus turns the experience of the Syrian battlefield into a model for transnational political participation, linking the representation of the conflict to a radicalization narrative centred increasingly on the reproduction of action and belonging beyond territorial control.

4.3.3 Decentralization of Authority

Rumiyah 1 was published in September 2016, at a moment when ISIS was already experiencing territorial losses, although it still controlled approximately 103,000 km² across Syria and Iraq (Kaczkowski and al., 2021). This context is important because the magazine does not present territorial rules as having disappeared. Instead, its use becomes less reliant on direct territorial control. This can be seen in how *Rumiyah* defines obedience (Rumiyah 1, pp7-8). However, obidience is not only shown as surrendering to a specific local government. The organization continues to be the source of authority even when individuals responding to that

authority no longer depend on direct institutional oversight. From a CDA viewpoint, this alters how the individual is shown whithin the power dynamic. The “subject” or “individual” is seen as responsible for turning an established ideological framework into actions, rather than just being a follower of orders. From a sociology of power viewpoint, this indicates a change in how power is reproduced : authority becomes less dependent on forceful or administrative ability and more relient on the internalization of norms that guide individual actions worlwide (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012). The significance of this change for the research question is that the evolving conditions of the Syrian conflict did not only reduce ISIS's ability to exercise power. They aided in reorganizing its methods. *Rumiyah 1* keeps a central source of legitimacy while allowing the actual use of authority to become more spread out.

4.3.4 Transforming the audience

Who is *Rumiyah* speaking to ? The magazine builds a layered community with individuals in hierarchical roles supporting its objectives. This hierarchy is illustrated by imperatives like the need for allegiance and active participation, framing belonging as a dynamic role within a normative system. Statements like *"The kafir blood is halal for you, so shed it*" (*Rumiyah* 1, p.34) highlight the sacralization of violence and dehumanization of adversaries. The text ranks participation from fighters to supporters, elevating combat as the highest duty but also equates non-combat support to fighting, expanding its base of power. Scholars are valued only when their knowledge leads to action, ensuring all contributions align with the cause. By distinguishing between global and territorial duties, ISIS focuses on power away from territory to functional integration. With diminishing territorial control, *Rumiyah* shifts authority to norm-based structures, maintaining influence through a centralized agenda. In summary, ISIS adapts its power dynamics through discourse, broadening authority vectors and sustaining legitimacy beyond territorial limits. In the section *The Religion of Islam and the Jama’ah of the Muslims* (Rumiyah 1, p.4-8) explains the community with five liked main pillars: *hijrah,* hearing*,* obedience*, jama’ah* and *jihad*. Importantly, these points are linked to various needs: there is no hearing, following, or, *jama’ah* without loyalty and/or leadership, no *hijra* without safety and help; and no *jihad* without readiness, outpost and combat (Rumiyah 1, p. 8). Participation is therefore, linked with multiple aspects. Through the lens of CDA, the text does not construct participation as a single act. It breaks the relationship between the individual and the *jama‘ah* into a series of functions and

obligations (van der Krogt, 2020). The discourse first builds a shared group belonging –"the muslims"- and then links various behaviours to being part of the group. The use of clear statements like "*there is no…" (Rumiyah 1 p.8)* makes these connections mandatory. Being part of *ISIS* is not just an identity: it turns into a stadardized role. Being involved with ISIS is not merely a label; it turns into a specific function. This is supported by the separation between people who "*fought with their money and lives*" and those who "*provided shelter and help*" (Rumiyah 1, p. 8–9). From a CDA viewpoint, the audience is formed through various social functions, while the claim that *"there is no jama'as except with imarah, and no imarah except with obedience"* (*Rumiyah* 1, p. 8) keeps these functions subordinate to a singular source of authority. *Rumiyah* shapes spread-out individuals as different paths through which the same normative system can function.

5. Comparative discussions and main findings

The comparison of *Dabiq 1*, *Dabiq 7*, and *Rumiyah 1* shows that the changing conditions of the Syrian civil war reshaped how ISIS reproduced political authority. Rather than a shift from a "territorial" to a "global" ideology, territorial decline altered the relationship between territory, legitimacy, political authority, and participation. The ideological foundations remained largely stable, but their functions within ISIS's discourse were reconfigured (Fairclough, 1992, 2003).

5.1 Continuities: what did not change

Our first finding is the persistence of the ideological foundations through which ISIS constructs political authority. Across *Dabiq 1*, *Dabiq 7,* and *Rumiyah 1,* the Caliphate stands as the central political point, while religious duty, *jihad*, martyrdom and the opposition between believers and *Kufr* continue to shape the justification of violent actions. This is particularly visible in the representation of political authority. In *Dabiq,* the Islamic State is shown as a current political system whose right to rule is backed by land control, military growth and management. Political power is strongly linked to physical abilities, hensed by land control, that make the reader give political significance to the Caliphate.

In *Rumiyah,* the assertion of the Caliphate continues even with the reduction of territories. The same applies to religious legitimacy. In both publications, mentions of religion create the standard framework that shows political power as valid and political actions as necessary. However, their roles shift across the publications. In *Dabiq,* religious validity can be strengthened by success in land, and military, while in *Rumiyah,* it becomes more crucial as a source of validity that is not reliant on land gains (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012)

5.2 Ruptures: what changed?

The main rupture concerns the evolutative relationship between territoriality and political participation. In *Dabiq,* participation is closely linked to the territorial project : *hijra, jihad* and involvement in state-building connect individual action to the construction of the Caliphate. In *Rumiyah,* weakening territorial control, weakens this connection, allowing participation in "state-building" to be constructed beyond Syrian control. Physical incorporation becomes less central. This shift is not only geographical. It reflects a change in the conditions through which political power can be exercised. Individual actions and ideological commitment become increasingly important components of ISIS propaganda, allowing the link between the individuality and the political project to be maintained despite its increasingly fragile boundaries foundations. The same reconfiguration emerges in the representation of the Syrian conflict. Across *Dabiq,* military struggle is linked to expansion and territorial achievement. In *Rumiyah,* the struggle remains meaningful through persistence and continued commitment. It signals a more profound change in how political participation can contribute to the reproduction of authority when incorporating people into territories is no longer enough to keep it going.

5.3 The evolution of ISIS's discursive strategy: How did ISIS make this transformation possible?

The comparison between *Dabiq 1*, *Dabiq 7* and *Rumiyah 1* suggests that ISIS discursive strategy evolved through the reorganisation of existing ideological elements, rather than through the introduction of new ideological foundations. In *Dabiq*, these elements are articulated within a political system in which territorial gains, religious legitimacy, and military victories reinforce one another and contribute to the legitimation of the Caliphate. In *Rumiyah,* their connection relies less on political successes and is more focused on the ongoing ideological goals. The discourse

reconfigures existing elements, emphasising religious obligation, *jihād*, and struggle. The same ideas can carry out different political roles when their connection to nearby social factors shifts, in this case the fall of the Caliphate from spring 2017 onwards (Fairclough, 1992, 2003).

5.4 From State-building to ideological persistence: A CDA and sociology of power interpretation

The changes identified across the corpus point to a reconfiguration of the resources through which political authority is sustained. In *Dabiq*, territorial control, military capacity, and governance reinforce the political claim of the Caliphate. In *Rumiyah*, the weakening of these resources increases the relative importance of ideological and symbolic forms of legitimation. From a sociology of power perspective, this does not imply the disappearance of political power, but a change in the resources through which power relations are maintained (Izquierdo Brichs, 2012). The Caliphate remains the central source of political authority, while its relationship with individual participation becomes less dependent on territorial incorporation. This reconfiguration is also discursive. In this sense, discourse contributes to maintaining the political significance of the Caliphate despite the weakening of its material foundations (Fairclough, 1992, 2003).

6. Conclusion

In a nutshell, comparing *Dabiq 1, Dabiq 7,* and *Rumiyah 1* shows that the evolution of the Syrian civil war did not change the core ideological basis of ISIS's political goals; rather, it modified the circumstances and methods by which political authority could be maintained. Instead of a straightforward change from a "territorial" to "global" ideology, the results indicate a change in how territory, legitimacy, authority and participation are connected. This research, emphazises the need to consider the historical and social backgrounds where this change in discussion happens (Reisigl & Wodak, 2009). In *Dabiq 1* and *Dabiq* 7, military struggle is closely linked to victory, *tamaddud* (expansion), and the establishment of the Caliphate. In *Rumiyah* 1, published under conditions of decreasing territorial control, the struggle remains central but is increasingly articulated through determination, duty, and continued commitment beyond the borders of the Caliphate. While the conflict still remained, its political function changed with ISIS's evolving position. The construction of political authority reflects a similar change. The *Caliphate,* remains as a core principle of the fight, but is reconfigured discursively: the relation to material power is not the same. In *Dabiq,* control of land, growth of the military and governance help shape its image as a State. In *Rumiyah,* the material foundations are weaker although the claim to power still exists. Hence, religious and ideological references take on more importance to maintain credibility. The corpus indicates a shift in the resources backing political power, rather than the end of the political power itself. The link between individuals and the political project also shifts. In *Dabiq, hijrah, jihad* and state building closely tie personal involvement to geographic inclusion. In *Rumiyah,* the focus on *jama'ah,* obedience, support, and *jihad* in foreign territories, offers different ways to engage whitin the same ethical structure.

Authority still focuses on the same political and religious legitimacy, while the individuals become key actors. As a result, radicalization dynamics are not just spread over a larger area; the role given to the individuals within the political plan is also changed. These results, suggest that the resources, backing political authority were reordered. When its grip on territory loosened, the Caliphate relied more on religious, ideological and symbolic backing to keep political standing. Territorial decline therefore reconfigured, rather than removed ISIS's political authority. The ideological foundations remained largely stable, but their relationship with territory, legitimacy, and participation changed.

Further research could expand on these findings by examining their implications for counter-radicalization. If political participation becomes less tied to physical territory, counter-radicalization approaches may need to consider how power, belonging, and participation are constructed beyond territorial spaces. This could be examined through a comparison of different jihadist groups and their use of online platforms, in order to assess whether similar discursive changes occur when territorial control declines.

GLOSSARY

Note: This glossary is intended as a support for non-specialised readers. It offers simplified definition without aiming for strict academic demonstration.

Bay'ah: An oath of loyalty where an individual promises support to a leader or political power. Traditionally, *bay'ah* has been linked to acknowledging political leadership in the Muslim community. In the ISIS papers, the idea is used to express loyalty.

Khilāfah (***Caliphate)*:**The institution of political leadership of the Muslim community, historically associated with the office of the caliph (*khalīfah*).

Dāʿish/ ISIS : Arabic acronym referring to the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS), also known as the Islamic State (IS).

Dīwān: An administrative department or bureau. In the Islamic State's institutional vocabulary, *dīwān* refers to an administrative body responsible for a specific area of governance or organisation.

Hijrah: Migration undertaken for religious purposes, most notably referring to the Prophet Muhammad's migration from Mecca to Medina in 622 CE.

Ḥudūd: The plural of *hadd*, referring to fixed punishments prescribed within classical Islamic jurisprudence for specific offences. The term is commonly associated with punishments for offences such as theft, adultery, and the consumption of alcohol.

Imāmah: The institution or concept of religious and political leadership within the Muslim community. In different Islamic traditions, the term carries distinct theological and political meanings.

Jamāʿah: A community, congregation, or collective group.

Jihād: A concept generally referring to struggle or striving in the path of God. Its meaning can vary across Islamic theological, legal, and historical traditions. This term is not limited to arm struggle.

Jund: An Arabic term, referring to a soldier or member of a military force.

Kāfir/Kufr: *Kāfir* refers to an Arabic term, referring to an unbeliever or non-believer. *Kufr* on the contrary refers to disbelief.

Sharīʿah: An ample Islamic term, that pertains to the beliefs and rules connected with Islamic law and path. How it is understood and used has differed among Islamic legal customs and

historical situations. In ISIS communication, Sharia (*Sharīʿah*) is shown as the standard foundation of political and social structure and is utilized to back the group's assertion of rightful rules.

Tawḥīd: The doctrine of the oneness and unity of God, constituting a central principle of Islamic theology.

Tamaddud: An Arabic word that means expansion, extension, or spreading out.

Ummah: Arabic term, referring to the *community* of Muslims. This term denotes a transnationality that goes beyond individual political or territorial frontiers.

Wilāyah (Wilayat): From the Arabic verb *Waliya* that means *Govern* or *to govern.* Several meanings derive from this definition, including authority, jurisdiction, or guardian depending on the context. In the Islamic State vocabulary, it refers to a province or territorial division of the organisation.

Zakāt: A religious obligation involving the giving of a specified portion of certain forms of wealth to designated beneficiaries. It constitutes one of the Five Pillars of Islam.

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